



Communicative Democracy and Voter Choice: Evidence From a Conjoint Analysis in Taiwan

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journals.sagepub.com/home/psrev**Chia-hung Tsai¹ and Ching-Hsing Wang²** 

Abstract

While prior scholarship has dedicated substantial attention to theoretically discussing communicative democracy, there has been a notable dearth of empirical research examining its political implications. This study endeavors to bridge this gap by exploring the impact of prioritizing communicative democracy in policy-making on electoral support. Through a conjoint experiment conducted in Taiwan, this study finds that candidates who emphasize communicative democracy, characterized by transparent communication, active engagement, and meaningful dialogue, are more likely to be chosen by voters over those who focus on majority rule. This preference highlights a broader desire for inclusivity and policies reflecting diverse viewpoints. As the first empirical investigation, the findings contribute to our understanding of voter values around communication and inclusivity in democracy, indicating a shift toward valuing collaborative policy development.

Keywords

communicative democracy, majority rule, conjoint analysis, policy-making principle, Taiwan

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Introduction

Political polarization, marked by intense partisan loyalty and distrust in government when the opposing party is in power, threatens democracy globally. This phenomenon, often exacerbated by populist and anti-establishment movements, leads to political disengagement among moderates. Scholars suggest deliberative democracy, which emphasizes policy-making through informed debate, as a potential remedy. However, its impact is

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limited if individuals remain disengaged. As an alternative, communicative democracy arises, prioritizing open communication and a vibrant public sphere for diverse viewpoints. Unlike deliberative democracy, which focuses on reaching consensus through discussion, communicative democracy emphasizes the importance of a dynamic exchange of perspectives to address political polarization.

Given that communicative democracy seeks to enhance and facilitate public discourse, deliberation, and engagement among citizens, it could stand out as a better remedy for political polarization (Frye, 2021). While prior research has examined the impact of deliberative democracy on political polarization (Fishkin et al., 2021; Stasavage, 2007), there has been limited scholarly focus on the connection between communicative democracy and political polarization. Therefore, this study is pioneering in its empirical exploration of communicative democracy as a non-institutional approach to mitigating political polarization. It specifically selects Taiwan for analysis due to its well-established democratic framework, marked by high levels of political engagement, a competitive electoral system, and strong protections for civil liberties. Despite its democratic strengths, Taiwan grapples with deep political polarization, which manifests in both domestic affairs and international relations, particularly in its complex relationship with China. Domestically, this polarization is reflected in sharp divides between political parties, with issues like national identity fueling intense debate. The increasing influence of ideological activists and the rise of cultural issues have contributed to a more polarized political landscape (Clark and Tan, 2012). On the international stage, Taiwan's polarization is most apparent in its relations with China, where contrasting views on sovereignty, independence, and security shape policy and public opinion, influencing both diplomatic efforts and regional stability. Research has shown that Taiwanese people have a polarized polarization of two major parties' positions on the unification-independence issue (Hsiao and Yu, 2020). Moreover, the shift in the composition of party identifiers has the potential to alter the distribution of views on unification and independence (Wang, 2019). This situation presents an optimal setting to examine the effectiveness of communicative democracy in real-world scenarios and its impact on voting behavior. Furthermore, investigating communicative democracy within the Taiwanese context offers crucial insights for broader political science research. By assessing the influence of communicative democracy on voter support in Taiwan, the study provides a basis for comparing its effects across different democratic environments, thereby deepening our comprehension of both the general and specific consequences of communicative democracy on political landscapes.

Through a conjoint experiment conducted in Taiwan, this study demonstrates a preference for communicative democracy over traditional majority rule. It also reveals that younger people are more inclined toward communicative democracy, with an individual's occupation influencing their democratic preferences. A significant contribution of this study is the suggestion that the democratic process benefits from greater inclusivity and the acknowledgment of diverse perspectives. This offers valuable insights for those studying political theory and the dynamics of political polarization. The structure of the study is organized as follows: the second section introduces communicative democracy; the third section explores the interplay between electoral systems, political polarization, and democracy; the fourth section sets forth the hypotheses for empirical testing; the fifth section details the experimental methodology; the sixth section reports on the findings; and the concluding section summarizes the study's main discoveries and their implications for enhancing democratic practices.

What Is Communicative Democracy?

Since ancient Greece, self-governance has been a political ideal, where citizens can vote on leadership and issues in the assembly. By the late eighteenth century, nation-states began replacing dynastic monarchies, with self-determination and sovereignty becoming key legitimacy standards grounded in the people's consent. Representative democracy, emphasizing civil liberties and universal suffrage, ensures equality without privileges based on inherent differences. As nation-states have developed, societal diversity has increased, leading to distinctions in class, religion, occupation, and race.

Under the principle of popular sovereignty, citizens elect representatives to make laws and form governments. Countries may implement majority rule or a proportional representation (PR) system for elections, as described by Lijphart (1984). The PR system aims to mirror the interests of various social groups, leading to a more inclusive government compared to majority rule. Nonetheless, even with PR, addressing the underlying social disparities remains a challenge. As individuals increasingly identify with multiple groups, reaching a consensus among diverse social factions becomes more complex, complicating the dynamics of representation. Consequently, neither PR nor majority rule systems fully accommodate this multifaceted group representation, amid rising political polarization and the persistence of anti-democracy parties. This scenario suggests that liberal representative democracy is facing significant challenges, without a clear resolution in sight.

Deliberative democracy, drawing inspiration from the dialogical and deliberative practices of ancient city-state democracies, as noted by Fishkin (1997), advocates for a process where participants articulate their political views, enhancing decision-making (Spragens, 1990). Chappell (2012) emphasizes the importance of inclusivity in deliberative democracy, where through dialogue, individuals open up to alternative perspectives, enriching their understanding of complex issues (Fishkin, 1997). While deliberative democracy encourages reaching consensus through voting or bargaining (Chappell, 2012; Cohen, 1989), it may not fully acknowledge the importance of diverse identities and experiences (Healy, 2011), potentially overlooking the nuanced differences among participants.

Building on her critique of exclusion and domination, Iris Marion Young (1990) contends that modernization has failed to eradicate social divisions. She calls for a democracy that appreciates cultural diversity and "group-conscious policies," challenging the notion that all groups have equal opportunities. Young suggests that understanding others often mistakenly relies on identifying commonalities rather than embracing differences. According to her, the essence of democracy lies in engaging with and recognizing the unique viewpoints of oppressed or marginalized groups, rather than merely tallying individual preferences. Young advocates for enhancing deliberative democracy with a "communicative" strategy that respects and acknowledges social variances and the potential influence of power in dialogue (Healy, 2011). This approach stresses the need for cultural sensitivity in deliberative methods, urging a shift toward a model where different perspectives are not just heard but genuinely understood, facilitating a collective insight that goes beyond personal experiences.

Highlighting the pitfalls of sacrificing inclusivity for efficiency, Young and others like Fung (2004) argue for democratic processes that prioritize broad participation and the representation of diverse, particularly disadvantaged, voices. She proposes methods to combat both overt and subtle forms of exclusion, emphasizing the importance of acknowledging and responding to varied experiences and perspectives within public discourse.

Moreover, Young suggests that while experts may handle the technicalities of governance, the wider public should have a say in setting policy priorities, such as the relative importance of health care versus foreign policy. This notion underscores the concept of communicative democracy, which seeks to ground collective decision-making in wide-ranging, inclusive discussions that consider the main concerns and viewpoints of diverse groups.

However, communicative democracy faces skepticism for its perceived idealism and the practical challenges of implementing a decision-making mechanism that is inclusive yet effective. Critics point out its potential impracticality due to the lack of clear guidelines on facilitating and concluding debates. Despite these criticisms, the current climate of political polarization underscores the urgency of applying Young's theories to foster a more inclusive and participatory democracy. Communicative democracy's push for conversation over simple majority or PR contrasts with these models' focus on decision outcomes. Yet, its broader adoption remains limited, partly because of its ambitious aim to thoroughly democratize public discourse, a goal that faces practical and participatory hurdles. Nonetheless, embracing the principles of communicative democracy could pave the way for a democracy that genuinely reflects and respects the diversity of its constituents.

Election Systems, Polarization, and Democracy

Political polarization, characterized by ideological extremes and escalating hostility, is a growing issue across many countries, affecting both the public and political elites (Campbell, 2016). This phenomenon leads to increased hate speech, distrust, and negative partisanship, with serious implications for societal harmony and public policy (Osmundsen et al., 2021). Despite the median voter theorem suggesting political parties should gravitate toward centrist policies for broader appeal (Downs, 1957), recent trends show a bimodal distribution of political opinions, with parties appealing to their bases rather than converging toward the center.

Interestingly, political polarization persists in both majority and consensus democracies. In Europe, even with multiparty systems that theoretically encourage compromise, polarization levels are high, sometimes exceeding those in the United States (Reiljan, 2020). This suggests that the PR system, despite facilitating more inclusive politics, does not automatically mitigate polarization. Research indicates that countries with PR systems, multiparty coalitions, and federal structures exhibit lower levels of polarization, underscoring the value of inclusivity and consensus-building in political systems (Bernaerts et al., 2023).

To address the challenges of polarization, some scholars suggest fostering intergroup contact to reduce prejudice and improve cooperation (Allport, 1954; Pettigrew and Tropp, 2006). In the context of party politics, proposals include reforming congressional primaries and enhancing party control over donations to increase unity and dilute extremist influences (Kamarck, 2015; McCarty, 2015; Persily, 2015). Moreover, policy deliberation has been shown to decrease polarization by encouraging partisans to engage with diverse perspectives and seek accurate information (Fishkin et al., 2021).

Despite these strategies, deliberative democracy has been criticized for overlooking existing societal differences. Young (1997) proposed communicative democracy, emphasizing the need to recognize social differences and the role of power in discourse, and to pursue a more inclusive communication model. Young (2000) argued for a democracy

where inclusion is paramount, suggesting that such an approach could transform conflict into consensus and advance justice.

This backdrop sets the stage for exploring communicative democracy further. Although scholars like Fung (2004), Healy (2011), Chappell (2012) and Medina (2014) have discussed the concept extensively, empirical research on public perceptions of communicative democracy remains scarce. This study aims to bridge that gap by comparing majority rule with communicative democracy in a survey experiment, focusing on how people choose between these governance models, thereby contributing to the ongoing discourse on enhancing democratic inclusivity and consensus-building.

Research Hypotheses

The central hypothesis under scrutiny pertains to the influence of the policy-making formula, namely communicative democracy or majority rule, on the selection of candidates. Should this hypothesis hold true, it would carry substantial implications for the theory of democracy, yielding valuable insights. In addition, anticipation exists that individuals will display a preference for candidates who adopt the policy-making principle of communicative democracy. The underlying rationale behind this expectation is that communicative democracy inherently embraces inclusivity and responsiveness to the concerns of the populace. Palacios (2016) emphasizes the need for a dialogue between the norm of parity of participation, communicative democracy, and the matrix of oppression to design inclusive democratic processes. Healy (2011) further suggests a dialogical reappropriation of the deliberative model to enhance inclusiveness and responsiveness to difference. Naturally, there is a trade-off, as communicative democracy might entail complexity and time-intensive processes. Achieving consensus through deliberation and inclusion might not always be straightforward. Conversely, the majority rule approach seems efficient and possesses an initial appearance of democratic representation. It is a widely employed method in various scenarios. However, as societal attention increasingly gravitates toward matters of social justice that transcend aggregative democracy, a term coined by Young (2000), it becomes conceivable that candidates who champion the concept of communicative democracy would gain popularity.

From the demand side, empowerment theory may explain why people prefer candidates representing communicative democracy rather than majority rule. Empowerment theory emphasizes the importance of enabling people to gain control over their political environment, enhancing their ability to participate in decision-making, and improving their socio-political status (Bobo and Gilliam, 1990). Empowering individuals and groups creates a more inclusive and participatory political system where everyone can influence policies and decisions that impact their lives. Communicative democracy aligns with these goals by fostering inclusive dialogue, mutual understanding, and collaborative decision-making. It actively includes and values diverse voices and perspectives, resonating with the principles of empowerment. In a communicative democracy, people feel their opinions are heard and considered, leading to a sense of ownership and influence over political outcomes. This inclusive approach contrasts with majority rule, where the voices of minority groups might be overlooked or disregarded. By advocating for communicative democracy, a candidate demonstrates a commitment to creating an environment where all individuals, especially historically marginalized or underrepresented, can participate fully and effectively in the political process. This approach aligns with the core tenets of empowerment theory, which emphasizes enhancing people's ability to shape

their socio-political context and improving their socio-political status. Therefore, people are more likely to support a candidate who promotes communicative democracy because it offers a pathway to greater empowerment, ensuring their voices contribute to shaping policies and decisions that affect their lives. We set up the first hypothesis as follows:

Hypothesis 1: People prefer the candidate who holds the policy-making principle of communicative democracy rather than that who emphasizes the principle of majority rule.

Why Taiwan?

Preceding the early 1990s democratization, Taiwan was characterized by a “one-party-plus-independent” political framework, with the Kuomintang (KMT) as the predominant party (King, 1993). The KMT not only dominated in every level of government but also controlled social organizations and business. The emergence of the Democratic Progressive Party (DPP) in 1987, composed of democracy advocates championing significant political transformation, marked a pivotal juncture. Subsequent to presidential turnovers in 2000, 2008, and 2016, the DPP and KMT have assumed the mantle of major parties in the process of democratic consolidation. In 2019, Taipei Mayor Ko Wen-je established the Taiwan People’s Party (TPP), aiming at people who are tired of party polarization along the cleavage of national identity. The TPP positions itself as a centrist alternative to the KMT and the DPP and seeks to attract voters who are disillusioned with the traditional blue-green dichotomy, focusing instead on pragmatic governance, social welfare, and economic issues rather than ideological battles. By positioning itself as a moderate force, the TPP aims to unite people across political divides and offer a fresh perspective on Taiwan’s future in both domestic and international contexts. Given the KMT’s long-standing dominance in Taiwanese politics, it is reasonable to expect that supporters of the DPP and TPP would be more inclined to embrace the principles of communicative democracy. These supporters, seeking alternatives to the entrenched power structures of the KMT, are likely to prioritize transparency, inclusiveness, and active civic engagement in political processes, aligning with the core values of communicative democracy in their pursuit of more open and participatory governance. However, considering that the DPP has held power twice, it remains unclear to what extent the party is attentive to social group disparities and prioritizes communication over majority rule. Although the DPP’s progressive stance suggests a commitment to inclusive values, questions persist regarding the extent to which these ideals have been implemented in practice, particularly when the party holds power. This study contends that the divergence between the DPP’s political rhetoric and its governance may expose limitations in its commitment to communicative democracy. In addition, it argues that these principles may be more strongly advocated by emerging parties like the TPP, which aim to disrupt the established political order by promoting participation, transparency, and equitable representation. Consequently, this study argues that the value of communicative democracy is likely to be championed primarily by TPP supporters, while DPP and KMT supporters may place less emphasis on this principle when making their voting decisions. Therefore, we formulate the following hypothesis.¹

Hypothesis 2: TPP supporters are more likely to choose the candidate who embraces the policy-making principle of communicative democracy.

The candidates who align closely with the principles of communicative democracy are likely to garner greater popularity among younger people and individuals with higher levels of education, compared to other candidates. In the United States, for instance, it has been demonstrated that young individuals exhibit a significant concern for matters of social justice (Dalton, 2021). In the context of Taiwan, the youth are often characterized as idealistic and harboring anti-establishment sentiments. This is substantiated by the occurrence of at least two prominent student movements that have catalyzed shifts in the political landscape. The initial movement, known as the Wild Lily movement, catalyzed a series of constitutional reforms during the 1990s. The more recent Sunflower Movement in 2014 saw students occupying the legislative body in protest against the review of a trade and service pact with China. Their concerns were rooted in the potential adverse impact on retail workers and shop owners, given that the pact permitted Chinese individuals to engage in business operations and employ fellow nationals in Taiwan. In light of these observations, it is reasonable to formulate a hypothesis suggesting that younger respondents are more inclined to select candidates who embrace the principles of communicative democracy. This hypothesis is grounded in the understanding that the youth segment is predisposed to prioritize open communication, inclusivity, and consideration for various social perspectives, aligning with the tenets of communicative democracy. Hypotheses 3 and 4 are written as follows:

Hypothesis 3: Young respondents are more likely to choose the candidate who embraces the policy-making principle of communicative democracy.

Hypothesis 4: More educated respondents are more likely to choose the candidate who embraces the policy-making principle of communicative democracy.

This study also investigates whether the effect of emphasizing the policy-making principle on candidate preference would vary by empathy toward social group differences. Drawing from the tenets of communicative democracy theory, the recognition and inclusion of social group disparities hold pivotal importance within the framework of deliberation. While Taiwan does not experience racial issues, several groups within the society are deemed disadvantaged. Examples of such groups include women, indigenous people, individuals with disabilities, low-income seniors, and senior farmers. Protective legislations exist for women and indigenous people, with Taiwan standing as one of the few countries retaining gender quotas in local and national elections. Specifically, the local councilor elections mandate a 25% reservation for women, and in legislative elections, a minimum of 50% of women are to be elected via party lists. Indigenous representation is also facilitated through indigenous districts (six seats) within the Legislative Yuan. In addition, indigenous students are afforded “bonus points” in school entrance exams upon passing the aboriginal language test. Although formal measures are lacking to protect the rights of disabled, low-income, and senior individuals, these groups are eligible for pensions and support services. Despite the existing institutional framework, our endeavor seeks to assess the extent of public awareness regarding social group differences. This is accomplished by inquiring to what extent the respondents support or oppose gender quotas, pensions, and support services for these groups.² Using factor analysis, we distill the

shared aspects of the variables. Subsequently, we derive a factor score for each respondent, indicating their level of empathy toward social group disparities. A higher score corresponds to a heightened demonstration of empathy toward these disparities. Accordingly, we formulate the following hypothesis.

Hypothesis 5: The effect of emphasizing the policy-making principle of communicative democracy on candidate preference is contingent upon an individual's level of empathy toward social group differences.

Data and Research Design

The data for this study were collected through an Internet survey conducted between March 31 and April 11, 2022. The survey was administered by the Election Study Center (ESC) of the National Chengchi University in Taiwan. Eligible participants were individuals aged 18 or older and registered in Taiwan. The ESC sent out 11,327 invitation emails to panelists in their databank, receiving 1861 responses. Of those, 1211 completed the entire survey. Consequently, the response rate for the survey was 10.7% (1211 of 11,327). Table 1 presents the demographic distribution of the respondents. The respondents are typically male, between 40 and 49 years old, and hold college degrees or higher. Due to the slight demographic differences between the respondents and the population, this study does not aim to emphasize the external validity of its experimental findings heavily. Ethical approval was given by the Institutional Review Board at National Chengchi University. A consent protocol was used to ensure that all participants provided voluntary and informed consent and that no deceptive practices were involved in the process. Potential survey participants were sent email invitations to partake in our online surveys. Upon reading the research-related information and providing their consent, respondents clicked on the link in the email to proceed with answering the questions.

We conducted an online survey with the design of a conjoint experiment that belongs to the family of stated choice method. Conjoint experiment can be used to estimate the causal effects of multi-dimensional attributes and has been widely applied to marketing, transportation, health economics, and agricultural economic research. In recent times, political scientists have been increasingly focusing on experimental design. Nonetheless, standard survey experiments can only examine one isolated factor at a time. Conjoint experiment, on the other hand, allows researchers to identify the most influential component of a multidimensional treatment. Therefore, it has become one of the preferred methods in political science for addressing causal inference, and various researchers have employed this method to explore multidimensional preferences. For instance, Hainmueller et al. (2014) are credited with pioneering the use of conjoint analysis to identify determinants of preferences toward candidates and immigrants. They utilized the potential outcome framework to estimate the effects of multiple treatment components and introduced the average marginal component effect (AMCE) as the key quantity of interest. The AMCE represents the average marginal effect of a specific attribute across the joint distribution of the remaining attributes. Furthermore, Hainmueller et al. (2015) used conjoint analysis to study immigrant naturalization and found that their experimental results closely aligned with the survey on the immigrant referendum. On the other hand, Bansak et al. (2023) expanded on conjoint analysis by incorporating the directionality and intensity of multi-attribute preferences toward candidates. They demonstrated that the AMCE

Table 1. Demographic Distributions of Survey Respondents.

	<i>N</i>	%
Gender		
Female	562	46.4
Male	649	53.6
Age		
20–29 years	66	5.4
30–39 years	238	19.7
40–49 years	396	32.7
50–59 years	308	25.4
60 years and older	203	16.8
Education		
Junior high school or below	9	0.7
High school or vocational school	130	10.7
Junior college	203	16.8
College or above	869	71.8
Total	1211	100.0

could summarize the average effect of attributes like gender, age, and education on vote shares in an election. Other scholars have explored the practical applications of conjoint analysis in political research. Bansak et al. (2021) investigated the feasibility of including multiple attributes in conjoint analysis of candidate selection. Knudsen and Johannesson (2019) discussed how conjoint design can be used in political communication research, such as candidate choice and selective exposure. Abramson et al. (2022) argued that the AMCE can be characterized as an average of ideal points. However, they cautioned that unless the directions and intensities of preferences are uncorrelated, the AMCE for a particular candidate feature does not necessarily imply that the majority of respondents prefer that feature over the baseline.

Overall, the advantage of using conjoint experiments lies in its ability to analyze and understand how individuals make choices when faced with complex, multi-dimensional decisions. Therefore, we attempt to employ the design of a conjoint experiment to examine whether the idea of communicative democracy would matter for individual candidate preferences. Specifically, in our conjoint experiment, the respondents are presented with a series of tables showing random profiles of two hypothetical mayoral candidates. Each profile contains the following attributes: gender (female and male), party label (KMT, DPP, TPP, NPP, and Independent),³ age (38, 46, 51, and 64 years old), incumbency (incumbent and challenger), education (high school, college, university, and graduate school), experience (military, civil servant, teacher, business, labor, and farmer), policy-making principle (communicative democracy or majority rule). Previous research has indicated that in Taiwan, candidates' party affiliation, age, and educational background significantly influence voters' decisions, while incumbent candidates have benefited from the advantages of holding office (Chang et al., 2017; Wang, 2022; Wang et al., 2018; Yang and Lee, 2016). Furthermore, we assumed that policymakers would adhere to either the majority rule or the principle of communicative democracy. The majority rule entails granting authority to the government head based on the preferences of the majority. However, it has the potential to overlook the perspectives of the minority, leading to a

disregard for their voices. In contrast, communicative democracy emphasizes the value of respecting differences and fostering mutual trust. Unlike the majority rule, communicative democracy considers diverse opinions, seeking to make decisions that serve the best interests of all. For this study, the respondents are presented with two contrasting policy-making principles: making decisions based on the majority's viewpoint or communicating with individuals with different opinions. This dichotomous choice underscores the significance of communicative democracy as an alternative to the traditional majority rule, highlighting the importance of promoting inclusive and participatory policy-making processes. The comparison sheds light on different conceptions of democratic legitimacy. Majority rule typically garners legitimacy through the sheer number of votes, highlighting the power of numerical advantage. On the other hand, communicative democracy gains its legitimacy from the depth and quality of discussions, focusing on the collective comprehension and agreement among those involved. This distinction prompts crucial inquiries into the foundations of democratic legitimacy and examines how diverse methods manage the interplay between ensuring broad participation and maintaining decision-making efficiency. To put into practice the ideas of communicative democracy and majoritarian rule, this study employs the following statements in a conjoint experiment: "Since the government's work is seeking the interest of most people, the government should communicate with people of different opinions before making decisions," and "Since the government's work is seeking the interest of most people, the government should make decisions according to the opinion of the majority of people." That is, this study emphasizes communicative democracy by focusing on open dialogue and inclusive communication within democratic decision-making processes and highlights majority rule by centering on the preferences of the majority of people.

In Taiwan, citizens aged 20 years or above automatically qualify to vote. Before the election day, all eligible voters receive the election bulletin, which contains essential information about every candidate. The election bulletin includes details, such as the candidate's number, name, gender, age, education, party affiliation, experience, and platform. The profile used in this study consists of seven attributes, which partially mirror the actual election bulletin, except for the attribute of the policy-making principle. Using attributes that resemble the real election bulletin, the respondents are likely to be reminded of the bulletin and pay closer attention to the two fictional candidates presented. In addition, we assume that every voter would read the bulletin from top to bottom. This approach of following the order of the bulletin helps mitigate technical issues that could arise from randomizing the order of attributes. Furthermore, we have presented only two candidate profiles to streamline the analysis. In Taiwan, the mayoral election employs a single plurality rule. While there are typically up to three major candidates, the total number of candidates can exceed three. However, for this study, we have restricted the choice to two candidate profiles to ensure that the respondents can focus their attention on these specific options. Following the presentation of candidate profiles, we inquire with the respondents about their preferred choice among the candidates. Attributes of candidates are listed in Table A1 in Appendix 1. For further information on the wording of the questions, please refer to Table A2, followed by the screenshot of the conjoint experiment (Table A3).

To examine the effect of the policy-making principle on individual candidate preferences, we regress candidate preference on the variables that indicate the randomly assigned attribute values for each of the seven attributes. Through the random assignment of attribute levels, we can estimate the causal effect, that is, the AMCE, using ordinary

least squares (OLS) regression. Considering all possible combinations in this study, the AMCE for a specific attribute signifies the average difference in the respondents' binary choices between two candidates who differ in that attribute's levels.

Empirical Results

We initiate our investigation into the significance of communicative democracy concerning individual candidate preferences. Figure 1 illustrates the average preferences of respondents in our sample toward hypothetical candidates based on their background and platform. The solid circles indicate the estimated AMCEs for different attributes, while the horizontal bars, alongside the circles, represent the 95% confidence intervals. In the left section of Figure 1, we present 27 AMCE estimates, employing seven attribute levels as baselines. The dotted line represents zero change in the probability of candidate preference. According to Hainmueller et al. (2014), we interpret the AMCEs as the expected change in candidate preference when comparing a given attribute value to the baseline. At first glance, the primary finding suggests that communicative democracy is more favored as a basis for policy-making than majority rule. Specifically, communicative democracy is estimated to increase the likelihood of choosing a candidate by approximately 9.8 percentage points when compared to majority rule, which serves as the baseline. The 95% confidence interval for this estimate falls within the range of (5.86, 13.71). These results indicate that a consensus based on communication is preferred by a larger segment of the population. In contrast, the approach of majority rule, which may overlook minority opinions, is not consistently the most popular method for policy-making among the respondents.

In addition, on average, the incumbent candidate is observed to be more popular, with the estimated AMCE at approximately 6.6 percentage points and a 95% confidence interval spanning from 2.66 to 10.49. This finding supports the incumbency hypothesis, indicating that people tend to view the incumbent candidate as a safer option when faced with a choice between two hypothetical candidates. On the other hand, regarding the candidate's party label, the finding reveals a preference among respondents for independent and TPP candidates over the KMT candidates.⁴ However, this result only partially supports the party hypothesis, and one plausible explanation is the heterogeneity of partisan effects. As a considerable portion of the respondents do not align themselves with any political party,⁵ compared to the baseline, the average effect of choosing an independent candidate appears to be the most substantial among the various groups. Figure 2 presents the estimates of the model that are conditional on the respondent's partisanship. The analysis demonstrates distinct patterns: Pan-blue supporters favor the KMT candidate over the others, Pan-green supporters lean toward the DPP candidate, TPP supporters prefer their own party nominees over the baseline, and Independents tend to favor independent candidates. More importantly, consistent with our hypothesis, the findings reveal that TPP supporters are more likely to back candidates who prioritize the policy-making principle of communicative democracy. However, while this principle does not appear to influence the voting decisions of pan-blue supporters, there is evidence that pan-green supporters tend to favor candidates who also endorse communicative democracy in their policy-making approach. These results suggest that, alongside TPP supporters, DPP supporters also place importance on a candidate's commitment to communicative democracy when determining their vote. This highlights a broader trend within the pan-green camp

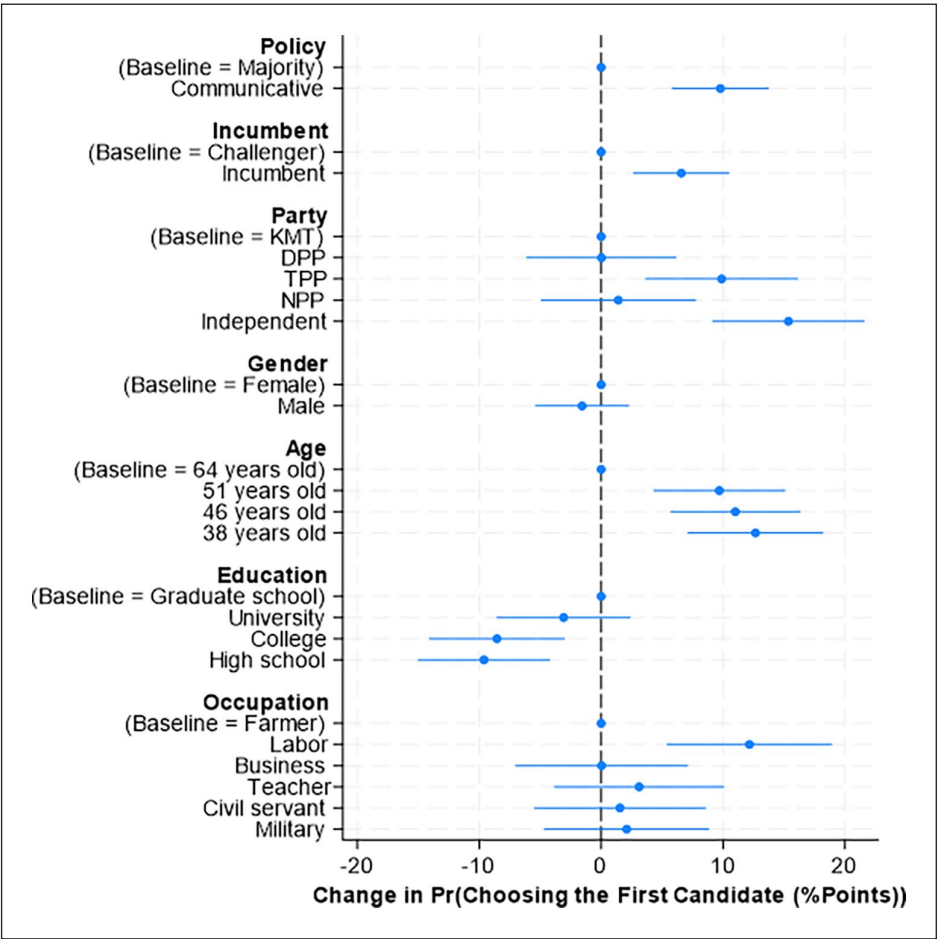


Figure 1. Probability of Candidate Choice.

toward valuing more participatory and inclusive forms of governance, suggesting that the DPP’s progressive image may still hold weight among its base, especially in relation to policy-making principles. Finally, in terms of candidate characteristics, such as gender, age, education, and previous or current occupation, the analysis suggests that the respondents have a preference for young and highly educated candidates. This result implies that people consider education an important qualification for effective leaders. However, when comparing candidates with a background in farming, only candidates with a labor-related background are viewed favorably. This result may reflect social desirability as labor candidates might be perceived as representatives of social equality and bottom-up participation.

After employing all attributes to conduct the AMCE estimator, the communicative democracy and incumbent hypotheses are confirmed, while the party hypothesis receives partial support. In addition, we would introduce a respondent-varying interaction to examine the effect of empathy toward group differences on candidate choice,

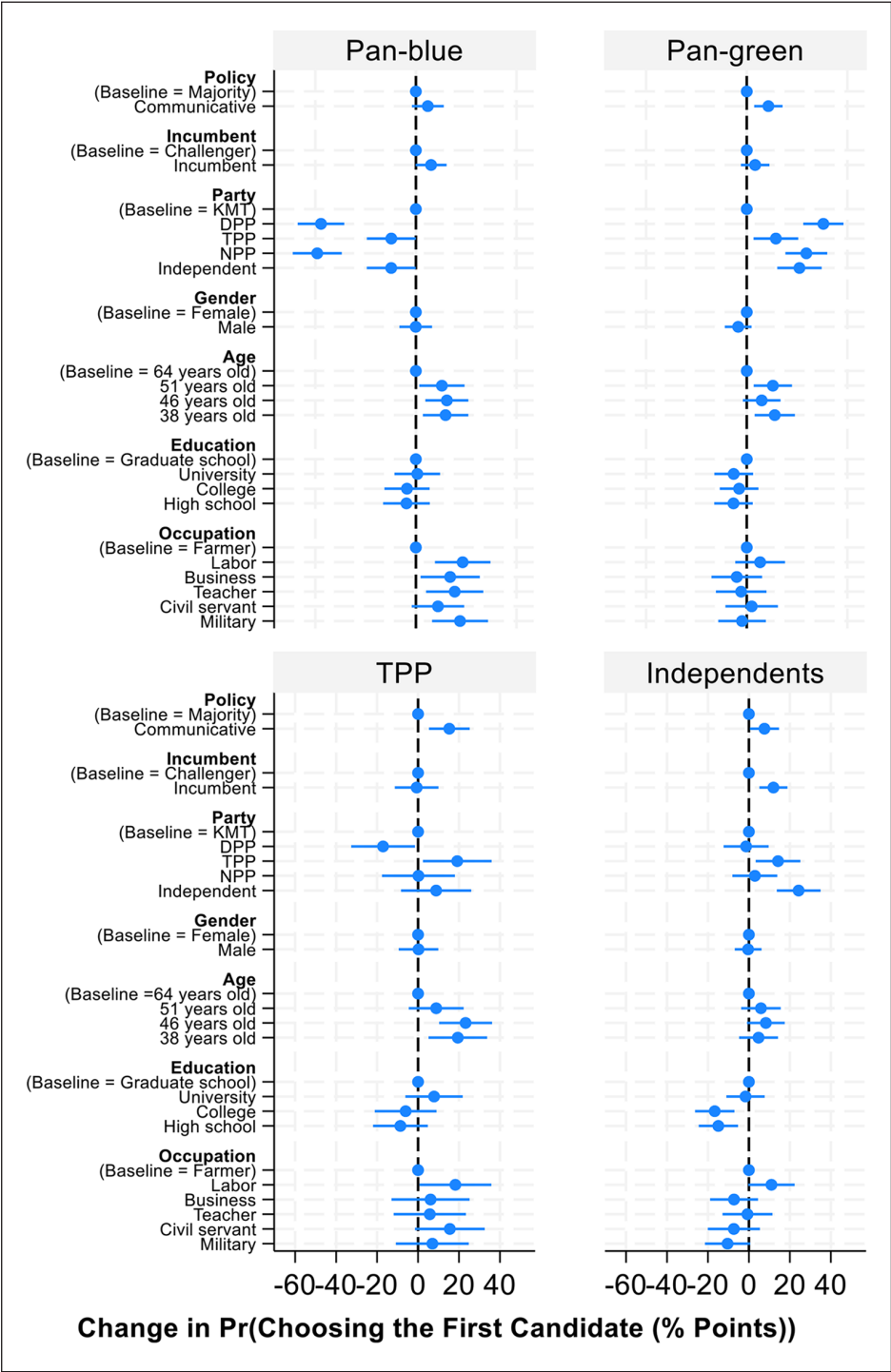


Figure 2. Probability of Candidate Choice Conditional on Partisanship.

considering the context of communicative democracy versus majority rule. Specifically, we would explore how the variation in candidate choice, attributed to the distinction between communicative democracy and majority rule, changes varying with different levels of discrete or continuous variables. Figure 3 presents four plots that categorize respondents according to the quantiles of their empathy levels. The results show that the influence of emphasizing the communicative democracy principle on candidate choice varies across individuals with different empathy levels. Specifically, the policy-making principle has no impact on the candidate choices of respondents with the lowest and highest empathy levels. However, for respondents with moderate empathy levels, the emphasis on communicative democracy significantly influences their candidate choices. Overall, these findings support our hypothesis that the effect of highlighting the communicative democracy principle on candidate preference depends on individuals' empathy levels.

Figure 4 demonstrates the impact of emphasizing the principle of communicative democracy on candidate preference among different age groups. The findings reveal that younger participants exhibit a more pronounced shift in the likelihood of selecting candidates who align with communicative democracy. This observation aligns with expectations, given that the younger cohort tends to possess greater idealism while having limited resources to influence policy-making processes. An illustrative instance involves various urban renewal initiatives that have entailed disputes over land expropriation. In these cases, numerous college students have actively assisted homeowners in their resistance against government-led house demolitions (Chen, 2017). Particularly, younger people often feel that existing political systems may not adequately address their concerns or represent their interests. Accordingly, they view communicative democracy as a way to break away from traditional top-down policy-making structures and foster a more direct connection between citizens and policymakers. This appeals to their desire for meaningful change and active involvement in shaping their communities.

Finally, Figure 5 illustrates the impact of emphasizing the principle of communicative democracy on individual candidate preferences, taking into account the respondents' educational backgrounds. For those with a college degree or higher, the emphasis on communicative democracy has a more significant influence than its unconditional effect. In contrast, for respondents with a high school education or less, the emphasis on communicative democracy does not reach statistical significance. These results suggest that individuals with higher education levels are more likely to favor leaders who prioritize communication over decision-making based strictly on majority rule.

Overall, the empirical findings of the conjoint analysis are consistent with the research hypotheses. In essence, the choice of candidate is genuinely influenced by democratic principles, whether it is communicative democracy or the majoritarian model. Incumbent candidates tend to receive higher preference from respondents on average. Notably, the substantial impact of independent candidates compared to the baseline is primarily observed among the respondents who do not align themselves with any political party, a fact likely contributing to this outcome.

On the other hand, some might argue that supporters of the ruling party and those of opposition parties have different preferences regarding policy-making principles. Specifically, supporters of the ruling party might favor the principle of majority rule, while opposition supporters might prefer communicative democracy. Consequently, this study examines whether these groups have heterogeneous treatment effects. As demonstrated in Figure 6, there is no significant difference in the effect of the policy-making

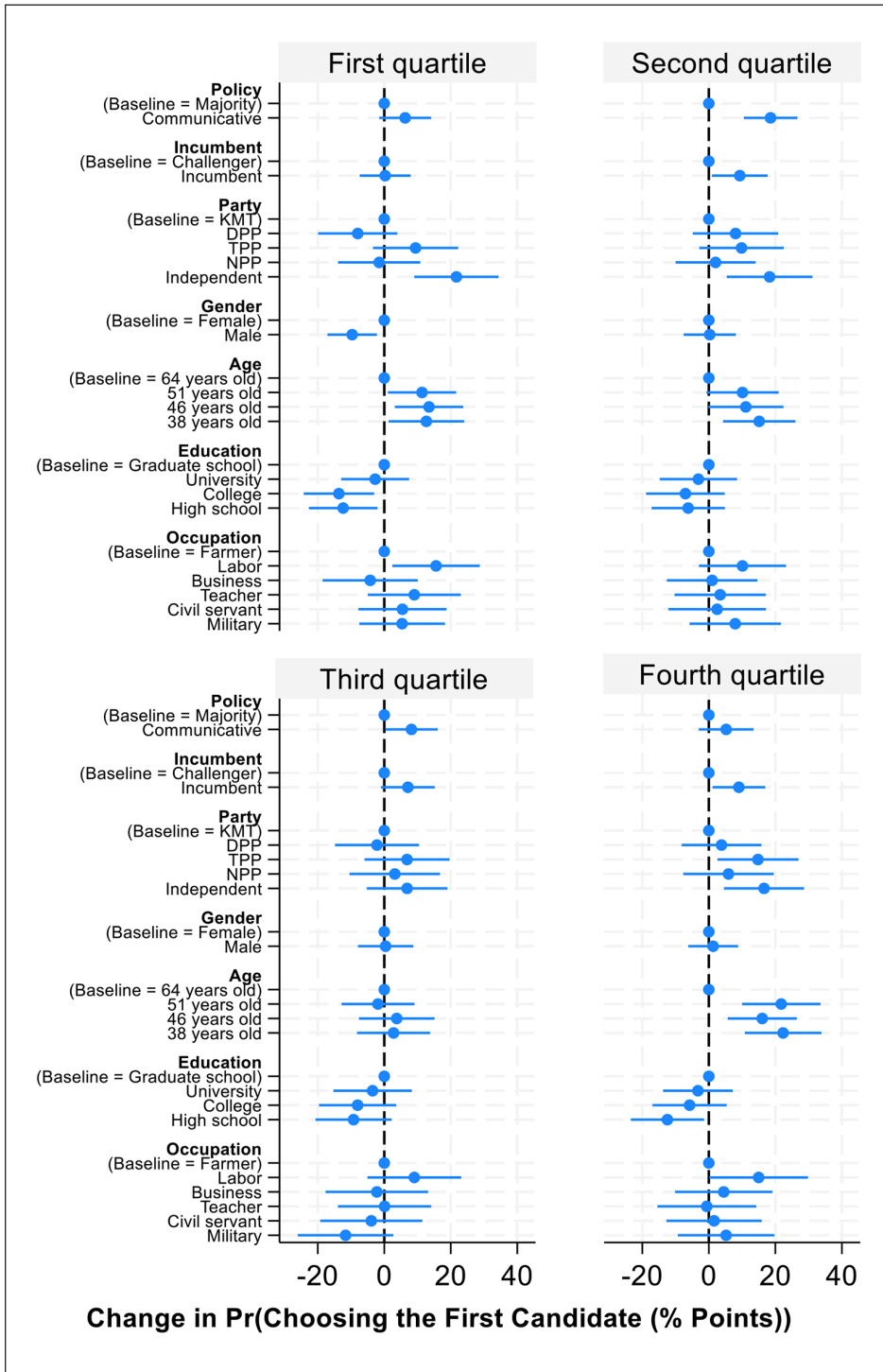


Figure 3. Probability of Candidate Choice Conditional on Different Levels of Empathy.

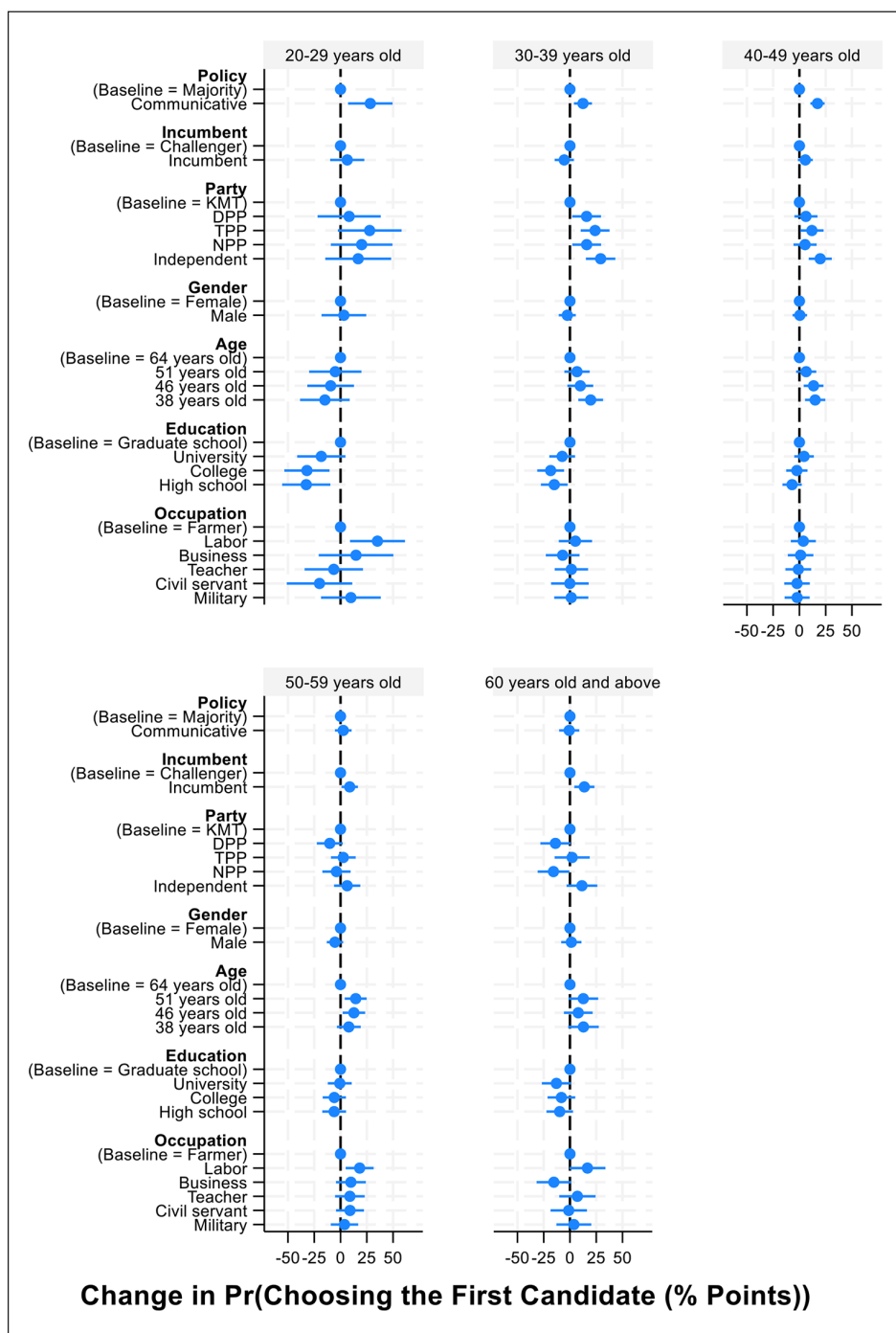


Figure 4. Probability of Candidate Choice Conditional on Different Age Groups.

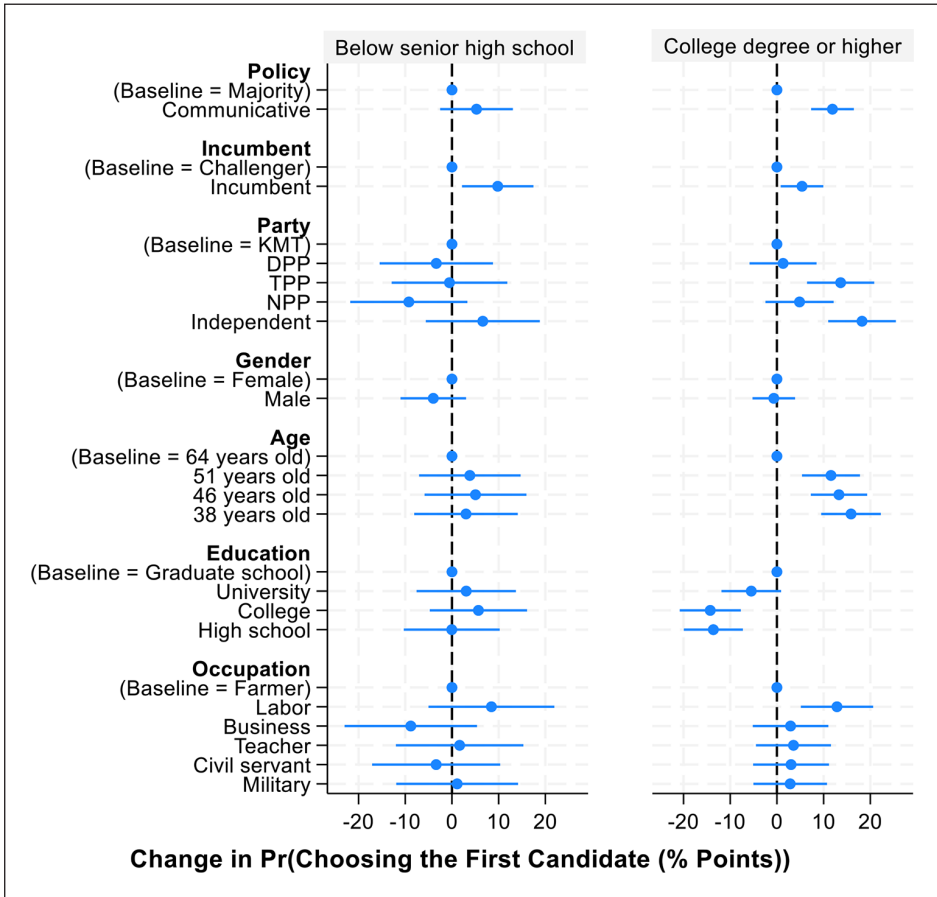


Figure 5. Probability of Candidate Choice Conditional on Different Levels of Education.

principle between ruling party supporters and opposition party supporters. Therefore, the relationship between policy-making principles and candidate preference does not depend on whether an individual's supportive party is in power.

Robustness Checks

To guarantee the results of randomized conjoint analysis, it is necessary to check the carryover effect, attribute over effect, and so on (Hainmueller et al., 2014). There is no carryover effect because every respondent has only one task in this conjoint analysis. This survey experiment fixes the order of attributes to make it similar to the actual election ballot. Therefore, there is no attribute order effect. However, it is important to check whether the order of the candidate profile has any profile order effects since the respondents may tend to choose the first or second profile regardless of the candidate attributes. This study may also have a randomization effect. That is, the assignment of profiles is not random, so that, profiles are not independent of respondent characteristics. Finally, some combinations of attributes may not be realistic. For example, it is rare to find a candidate

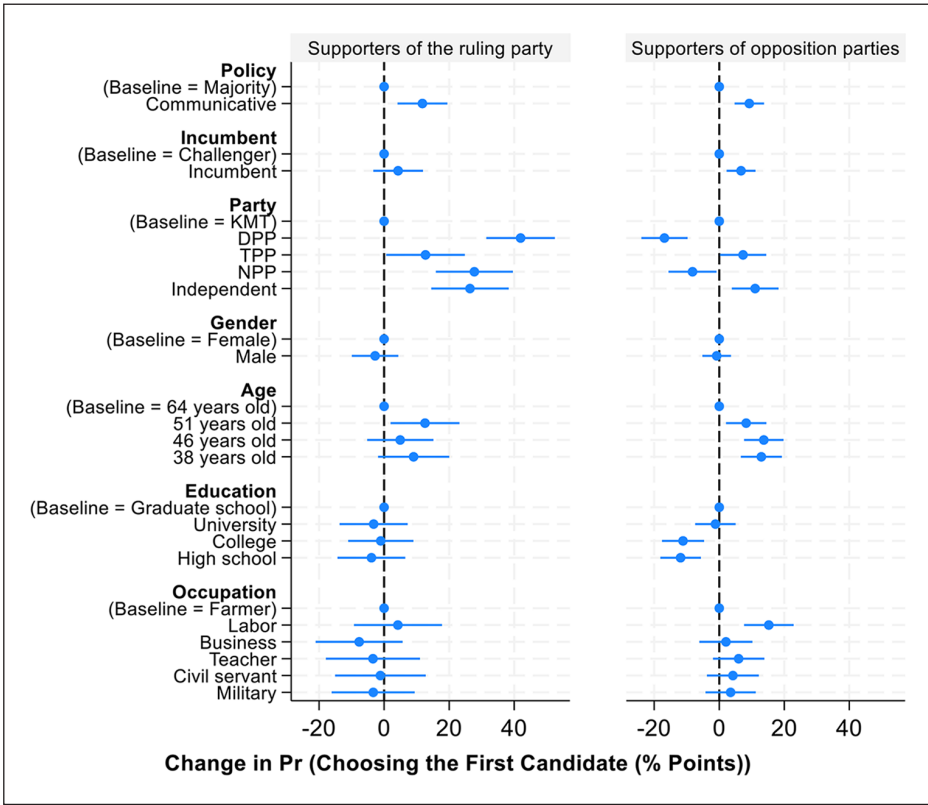


Figure 6. Probability of Candidate Choice Conditional on Supporters of the Ruling Party and Opposition Parties.

whose working experience is labor and whose highest degree is university. In this case, the respondents may never choose atypical profiles.

The first diagnostic examines the assumption of no profile order effects. This assumption implies that how the profiles are presented affects candidate choice. If there is a profile order effect, the estimated AMCEs for the profile on the right should differ from that on the left. Figure A1 in Appendix 1 shows similar AMCEs across two profile orders. It indicates that profile order does not exist.

The second diagnostic checks whether certain backgrounds of the respondents are assigned to specific candidate profiles. For example, male respondents view more male candidates than female ones. In this case, the rating of candidates varies with respondent characteristics. Figure A2 in Appendix 1 illustrates the rating of candidates 1 and 2 across three respondent characteristics: age, education, and occupation. The differences between the two candidate ratings are not significant across different levels of three respondent characteristics.

The third diagnostic is also about randomization. We examine whether the respondents' predispositions are independent of the assignment of candidate profiles. We conduct a regression analysis to explore this, regressing seven candidate attributes against the respondents' empathy levels toward unprivileged social groups. The omnibus *F*-test

yields a p -value of 0.36, indicating that the attributes do not systematically vary with the respondents' attitudes. In other words, this test does not diagnose imbalance.

Finally, it is important to ensure that the respondents would not specifically favor or avoid some atypical but not illogical combination of attributes. Following a review of the background information of mayor candidates across different elections, it was determined that candidates with the following rare attribute combinations were infrequent: having a high school degree and civil servant experience, possessing a university degree and worker experience, or holding a university degree and farmer experience. Among the 291 candidate profiles available, each containing one of these atypical combinations, a dummy variable was established to capture the influence of these profiles. A conjoint analysis was subsequently conducted. As illustrated in Figure A3 in Appendix 1, the impact of these atypical profiles does not exhibit statistical significance. This outcome suggests that respondents maintain consistency even when confronted with candidate profiles that deviate from the norm. In conclusion, our comprehensive validation procedures confirm that our conjoint analysis fulfills essential assumptions and that the outcomes can be deemed dependable.

Conclusion

The idea of communicative democracy refers to a democratic model that emphasizes open and inclusive communication among citizens and between citizens and their representatives. Although previous research has made a great effort to theoretically discuss communicative democracy, little scholarly attention has been paid to empirically examine the political consequences of communicative democracy. This study represents the first attempt to investigate whether the candidates who emphasize the policy-making principle of communicative democracy could help them receive electoral support. By conducting the conjoint experiment in Taiwan, this study finds that people are more likely to choose the candidate who highlights the principle of communicative democracy in the policy-making process than that who embraces the principle of majority rule. The finding indicates that people value candidates who prioritize open communication, active engagement, and dialogue within the policy-making process. The emphasis on communicative democracy also suggests a desire for inclusive participation, where citizens' voices are heard and considered, leading to policies that better reflect a wider range of perspectives. In addition, by valuing the principle of communicative democracy, people express a preference for candidates who are willing to engage in the process of long-term consensus-building. This approach may lead to more stable and sustainable policy outcomes that withstand changing political dynamics.

On the other hand, the findings of this study also contribute valuable insights into the domain of electoral research. Past studies have hardly looked into whether a candidate's policy-making principle would influence her, or his electoral performance and the outcomes of this study confirm that the policy-making principle adopted by a candidate has a significant effect on voter choice. Until now, most electoral studies have primarily focused on factors, such as party affiliation, candidate charisma, policy stances, and demographic characteristics as key determinants of voter choice. However, the role of a candidate's underlying philosophy or guiding principle in policy-making has received comparatively less attention. By delving into the relationship between a candidate's policy-making principle and her or his electoral performance, this study illuminates a new dimension of voter behavior. It underscores that beyond policy positions and personal

attributes, the fundamental values and approaches embraced by candidates play a pivotal role in influencing voter decision-making. This insight carries far-reaching implications for political campaigns, candidate strategies, and even the design of democratic institutions. It suggests that candidates who effectively communicate and embody policy-making principles aligned with voters' values and aspirations are more likely to resonate with the electorate and garner support.

While this study confirms the impact of emphasizing communicative democracy principles on voter preferences, it acknowledges certain constraints. Specifically, this study is limited to comparing communicative democracy with majority rule, leaving other policy-making principles unexamined. Moreover, this study is conducted in the context of Taiwan, a singular Asian democracy. Given the wide variety of political cultures and paths around the globe, further research is needed to determine if these findings are applicable elsewhere. Nonetheless, this does not imply this study's insights are restricted to Taiwan alone. The results may well argue for the global relevance of communicative democracy principles in shaping electoral politics, suggesting that preferences for candidates who engage in open communication, active participation, and meaningful dialogue could mirror a wider, possibly universal trend within democratic societies worldwide. As people across the globe become more interconnected and better informed, their demands for transparency, inclusivity, and participatory governance are likely to grow, indicating that the principles of communicative democracy might find resonance in diverse political environments and influence electoral decisions across various cultures and systems. In addition, although centered on Taiwan, this study's approach and outcomes offer a framework for similar investigations in varied political settings. By undertaking analogous research in different nations, scholars can explore how broadly the appreciation for communicative democracy principles in policy-making extends beyond cultural and political variances. Such comparative studies could shed light on global patterns in democratic values and electoral behavior, enriching our understanding of these phenomena's universality or particularity. In essence, this study not only contributes to the ongoing conversation on democratic theory and practice but also challenges both academics and practitioners to reevaluate the significance of communicative principles in the governance process. Through its empirical demonstration of these principles' electoral significance, the research encourages further inquiry into how democratic systems might evolve to better satisfy the needs of an increasingly participatory and well-informed public.

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Data availability

The data, code, and any additional materials required to replicate all analyses in this article are available upon request.

Declaration of conflicting interests

The authors declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

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Ethical statement

Ethical approval was given by the Institutional Review Board at National Chengchi University. All participants provided informed consent at the start of the survey, and no forms of deception or hidden purpose existed, so that all aspects were fully explained.

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Notes

1. In our survey, 230 respondents (19.0%) identified with the KMT, 318 respondents (26.3%) aligned with the DPP, and 183 respondents (15.1%) expressed support for the TPP.
2. This study evaluates the respondents' levels of empathy using six questions that gauge their support or opposition to gender quotas, educational benefits for indigenous people, job quotas for individuals with disabilities, subsidies for low-income seniors, subsidies for elderly farmers, and support for families facing life challenges, such as divorce, widowhood, domestic violence, or having an incarcerated spouse. These questions effectively measure empathy in Taiwan by focusing on social policies that influence marginalized or vulnerable groups, revealing the respondents' views on social justice, fairness, and compassion. Tailored to Taiwan's socio-cultural context, where issues like gender, indignity, disability, aging, and family welfare are prominent, the questions assess the respondents' willingness to support policies that strengthen social safety nets and promote equality, which are strong indicators of empathy. Besides, the result of Cronbach's alpha test indicates a reliability coefficient of 0.711, suggesting an acceptable level of internal consistency among these survey items used in the study.
3. Please refer to the glossary for the abbreviations of political party labels: Kuomintang (KMT), Democratic Progressive Party (DPP), Taiwan People's Party (TPP), and New Power Party (NPP).
4. Here, we code people who identify with the KMT, People's First Party (PFP), and New Party (NP) as Pan-blue. Blue is the major color of the KMT's party flag. We code people who identify with the DPP and Taiwan State Building as Pan-green. Green is the major color of the DPP's party flag. Both PFP and NP are KMT's sprinter parties. Taiwan State Building is a minor party. It supports Taiwan's independence, as the DPP states in its party platform.
5. The Election Study Center at National Chengchi University has tracked partisanship since 1992 by aggregating its public opinion polls every year. In 2022, 45% of the respondents expressed no affiliation with any party, while 30.8% identified with the DPP, 14.4% with the KMT, and 8.2% with the TPP. Please see the Election Study Center (2022).

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Author Biographies

Chia-hung Tsai received his Ph.D. in political science from the Ohio State University. He is a research fellow in the Election Study Center at National Chengchi University (NCCU) in Taiwan. He holds a joint appointment with the Graduate Institute of East Asian Studies at NCCU. His major fields are political behavior, public opinion, and methodology. He has served as a visiting scholar at Fairbanks Center for Chinese Studies, Harvard University.

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Appendix I

Table AI. Attributes of Candidates.

Attribute	Levels
Gender	Female, male
Party label	KMT, DPP, TPP, NPP, Independent ^a
Age	38, 46, 51, 64 years old
Incumbency	Incumbent, challenger
Education	High school, college, university, graduate school
Experience	Military, civil servant, teacher, business, labor, farmer
Policy-making principle	Communicative democracy, majority rule ^b

^aKuomintang (KMT) and Democratic Progressive Party (DPP) are two major parties. Taiwan People's Party (TPP) is the third largest party and New Power Party (NPP) is the fourth one. Some candidates are close to either party, but they choose to run the election as Independents because around 45% of voters identify with no party.

^bThe wording of communicative democracy is as follows: “Since the government’s work is seeking the interest of most people, the government should communicate with people of different opinions before making decisions.” The wording of majority rule is as follows: “Since the government’s work is seeking the interest of most people, the government should make decisions according to the opinion of the majority of people.”

Table A2. Operation of Individual-Level Variables.

Variable	Question	Options
Social difference	Do you support or oppose the quota of female representative?	Strongly oppose, oppose, neither oppose nor support, support, strongly support
	Do you support or oppose fair treatment of indigenous students?	Strongly oppose, oppose, neither oppose nor support, support, strongly support
	Do you support or oppose job security of disabled people?	Strongly oppose, oppose, neither oppose nor support, support, strongly support
	Do you agree or oppose pension for low-income senior people?	Strongly oppose, oppose, neither oppose nor support, support, strongly support
	Do you agree or oppose pension for senior farmers?	Strongly oppose, oppose, neither oppose nor support, support, strongly support
Partisanship	Which party do you identify with?	KMT, DPP, TPP, NPP, Independents
Job	What is your occupation?	Civil servant, manager, staff, labor, farmer, unemployed
Education	What is your highest degree?	Below senior high school, college degree or higher
Age	What year were you born?	20–29, 30–39, 40–49, 50–59, 60 years old and above

Table A3. Screenshot of Conjoint Experiment.

	1號候選人	2號候選人
性別	女	女
黨籍	無黨籍	國民黨
年齡	64	38
現任與否	新人	新人
最高學歷	專科	專科
主要經歷	軍	軍
針對重大議題的作法	政府施政是為了謀求最多人的福祉，所以應該根據多數人的意見決定。	政府施政是為了謀求最多人的福祉，所以應該根據多數人的意見決定。
請問您會投給哪一位候選人？		
請選擇	☐	☐

The first column in the top table lists each candidate's characteristics. From top to bottom, they are gender, party label, age, incumbency, education, job title, and issue position on policy-making. The second table shows the two options.

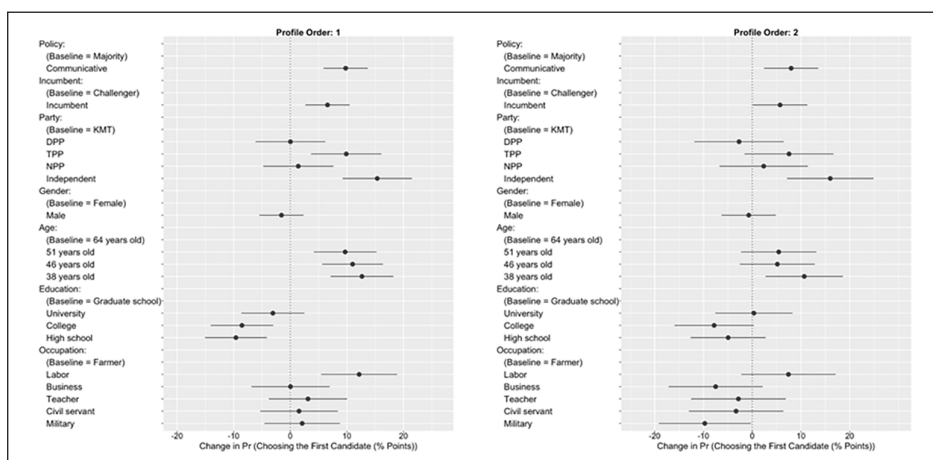


Figure A1. Diagnostic of Profile Order Effect.

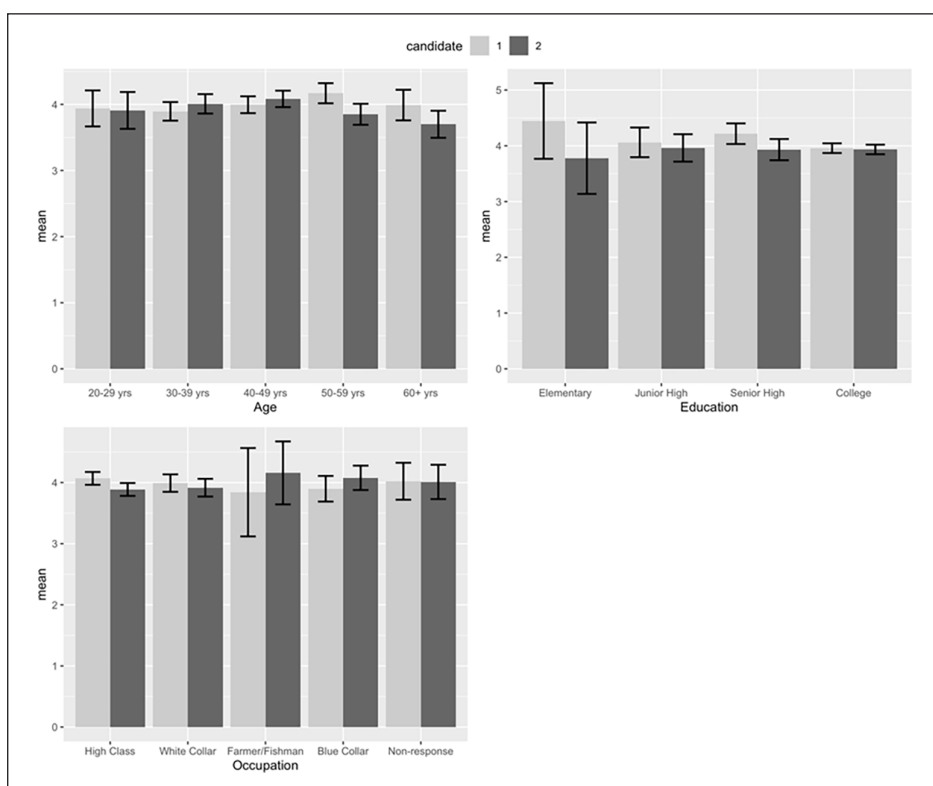


Figure A2. Diagnostic of Assignment of Candidate Profile Varying by Respondent Characteristics.

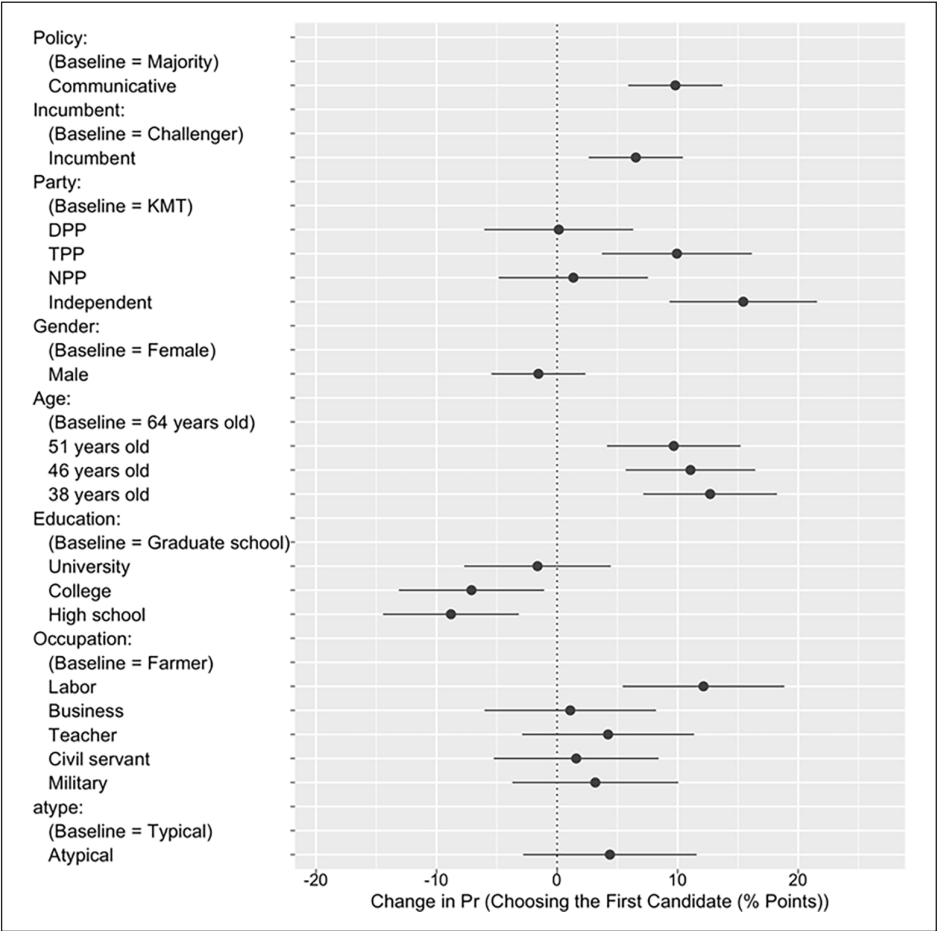


Figure A3. Diagnostic of Atypical Candidate Profile.